I made my way into the room where Leah was, my vision blurred. I squeezed her hand and said to her, “Leah, he went by a whirlwind into heaven.” And that was the moment I decided that my time as director of the Mossad must come to an end.

That same night another impromptu government meeting took place at IDF headquarters in Tel Aviv, in which Shimon Peres was appointed as acting prime minister and decisions were made regarding the arrangements for the funeral and mourning period.

I remember nothing of my journey home. All that night I lay awake in my bed, staring at the ceiling.

I informed Shimon Peres about my decision to step down from my job during our first work meeting. When he asked about my reasons for leaving, I explained to him that over the past six months I had already been speaking to the late prime minister Rabin about completing my tenure. I added that six-and-a-half intensive years on the job, working with two prime ministers as different from each other as Shamir and Rabin, had left me fulfilled and I felt it would be very difficult for me to continue in the role working with a third prime minister. Peres, in his thick voice, began by saying that it was not every day that a prime minister was assassinated in Israel, that Shin Bet head Gillon had already taken it upon himself to resign, and that an additional announcement that the director of the Mossad was also resigning would have a devastating effect on public morale. His reasoning resonated with me. I was convinced that it stemmed from genuine concern for the country. We agreed that I would remain in my position for another six months and that the official announcement would be made ahead of the next elections, when I would have served as Mossad director for seven years.

The director of the Mossad is directly subordinate to, and appointed by, the prime minister. Generally speaking, the prime minister tends to consult with other people, including of course the defense minister, on the matter of whom to appoint, but it is the prime minister who makes the ultimate decision. I was chosen to be the head of the Mossad by Yitzhak Shamir. Rabin, who was the defense minister at the time of my appointment, had suggested Amnon Lipkin-Shahak, then head of Military Intelligence, for the job. This did not interfere with the development of a close relationship between Rabin and me—both a working and a personal one. We had also